

Photo Courtesy: J&K INFORMATION DEPARTMENT



OMAR ABDULLAH
RECEIVING MANMOHAN,
FAROOQ ABDULLAH (RIGHT)

Packaged Hope

1996: Economic package, including **Rs 2,600** crore for the Udhampur-Baramulla rail link, announced

2002: Kashmir gets a **Rs 6,165**-crore package

2003: Another **Rs 3,000**-crore package announced

2004: Centre approves a reconstruction plan involving an outlay of **Rs 24,000** crore

2008: **Rs 1,600**-crore financial assistance to help Kashmiri Pandits return home announced

2009: Rail link inaugurated; **Rs 350** crore for the rehab of Dal and Nagin lakes and **Rs 125** crore for upgrading infrastructure in important towns announced

2010: Centre announces **Rs 900** crore for power sector; **Rs 90** crore for flood control; **Rs 473** crore for Ladakh renewable project

neither a developmental impetus nor a specific political agenda to the people.

Manmohan's two-day visit was preceded by some significant developments, chief among them being that the 'quiet diplomacy' to engage separatists in a dialogue had died an unceremonious death. The back channel efforts set off late last year by Home Minister P. Chidambaram were intended to use the extensive security grid as a box for all the political issues. The idea suffered a hard and possibly irreversible blow as separatists suspected the Government's concealed intent and rejected it. The separatists, particularly

"moderate" Mirwaiz Umar Farooq, had put in a lot of energy into a campaign for repeal of the Armed Forces Special Powers Act (AFSPA). Along with demilitarisation of civilian areas and release of political prisoners, Mirwaiz has consistently said that revoking the act was a prerequisite for creating a favourable atmosphere for dialogue.

In separate meetings with Manmohan, Chief Minister Omar Abdullah as well as the Opposition leader Mehbooba Mufti reiterated the demand for dealing with the AFSPA. "Because it is tailor-made for the armed forces, the act makes the army

the judge, jury and the hangman. There is an absence of transparency and people have lost faith in the system," Abdullah said.

That such pressure on Delhi over the AFSPA was effective is clear from the fact that Chidambaram had prepared amendments for the law to be made more transparent. But these were rejected by the army top brass. It was perhaps for the first time in Independent India's history that the army called the tune over a decision of the executive. This has only complicated the political fallout of Chidambaram's failed move. The scenario has been further aggravated by fresh evidence of human rights violations in the Machil killings of three innocent youth by the army. Manmohan was expected to respond to public sentiment as well as political pressure and chastise, if not condemn, it. Instead, during his speech at the convocation of Sher-e-Kashmir University of Agriculture Sciences and Technology, he was seen taking the army's side. "There are a handful of people who don't want any political process for empowering people to succeed. This is the reason that attempts to disturb the lives of people in the Vsalley continue from across the Line of Control. Our security agencies are forced to act in the wake of such incidents. Sometimes, innocent civilians have to suffer," he said.

This is being seen as an endorsement of the army's actions and has resulted in a sense of disbelief. So much so that when Manmohan repeated his offer of conditional talks with all groups who shun violence and terrorism, the separatists reacted with outrage. There is some consternation as the separatist groups that have been holding talks with Delhi so far are political organisations not involved with armed resistance. Further, the absence of condemnation of the army action over killings for monetary rewards and promotions has alienated even those who might have been inclined towards a fresh dialogue. Mirwaiz said the prime minister's statement "encouraged and justified" human rights violations by the army in Kashmir and pointed out that he expected Manmohan to talk tough about it while making it clear